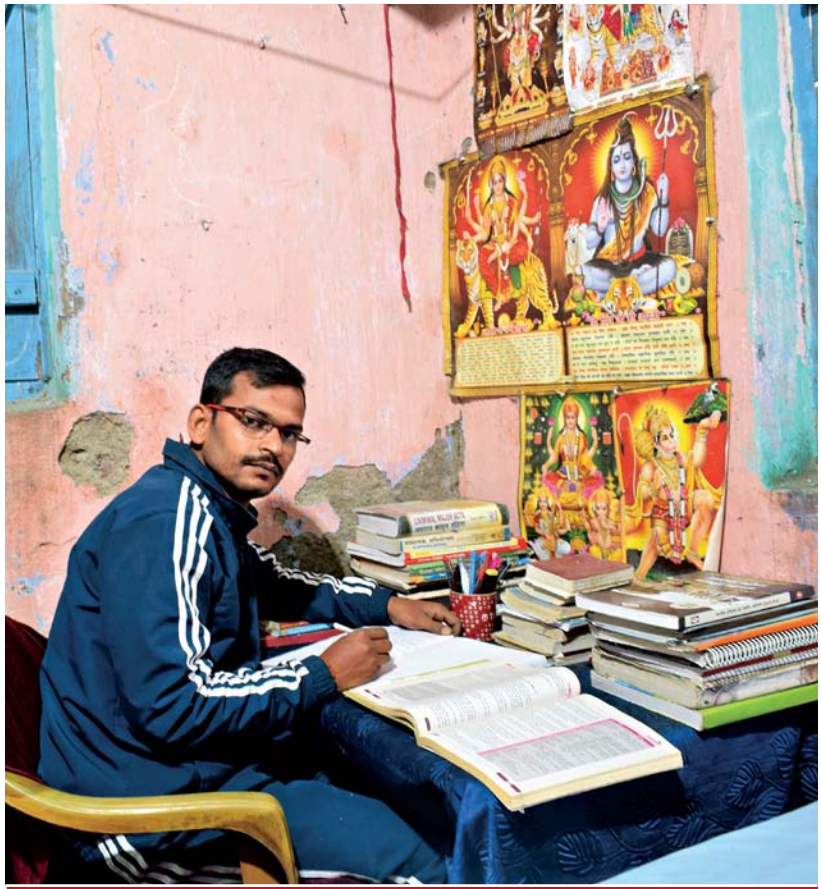


BIHAR: Gulab Gautam, 25, *B.Sc. (Chemistry)*

Job applied for: Multi-tasking non-technical staff

Total vacancies: 20,902; Total applications: 3 million

He may be preparing for several competitive exams, including for the Bihar Civil Services, but Gulab has his heart set on the police sub-inspector's post. This native of Akbarpur village in Nawada district has left the comfort of home—which has electricity, internet, television, home-cooked food and plenty of open space—to park himself in a 12ft x 8ft room at a boys' hostel inhabited by a bunch of like-minded youth. Their company, he says, "helps him stay grounded and motivated".

In 2019, Gulab took the examinations for recruitment to the Bihar Police and the Staff Selection Commission examination, but could not clear either. "Government jobs are the only hope for students like us," says Gulab, whose elder brother in the army supports his studies as his farmer father is too poor to do so. Gulab cooks his own food, hasn't watched television for more than five months and does not remember the last time he visited a theatre. He does not have a personal computer, but his mobile phone helps him access the examination content.

generates, the final selection being subject to separate specialised exams. The CET score shall be valid for three years. This, the government says, will "significantly reduce" the time taken by the whole cycle. Some departments even intend to do away with any second-level test and go ahead with hiring based on CET scores and physical/ medical tests.

The NRA is to go on stream this month, according to Jitendra Singh, the Union minister of state for personnel and public grievances. Assam has also initiated a common exam model for Grade II and IV employees across departments. And CM Bhupesh Baghel says his state's initiative—the Chhattisgarh Employment Mission—aims to create 1.2-1.5 million jobs in the next five years. A lot of such promises have, of course, remained in the realm of rhetoric in the past.

That larger circle remains a vicious one. Our year-on-year demographic spurt hit its peak in the early 1990s and stabilised: all through the '80-90s, we were adding about 17-19 million annually to our absolute numbers (by contrast, we added only 13 million in the previous year). Eventually, these individuals would grow to attain working age and the economy would need the space to absorb them. Luckily, that's also the period when reforms opened up several sectors. Data suggests the uptake was just about reasonable—61 million new jobs created in two decades, between 1991 and 2012, even if 90 per cent were in the informal sector. Anecdotally, everyone can attest to a boom and an expansion in employment, self-given or otherwise—think construction, real estate, telecom, tourism, food and hospitality, IT/ BPOs, MSMEs. But the story went sour in the late 2000s. The 'demographic dividend' that India had of a young working population was to last till roughly 2030-40. Unluckily, its onset coincided with the global downturn of 2008. And that was that. The anger we see on the streets comes from being robbed of that destiny. We have to correct history's anomaly—and fast. ■

–with Ashish Misra, Amitabh Srivastava, Rahul Noronha, Romita Datta, Rohit Parihar and Jeemon Jacob